ultimately went under liquidation after the loss of their biggest client. A similar fate befell an Italian firm in Bombay who tried to compete with Purshotamdas's firm. Purshotamdas's reputation as a businessman of courage and integrity was greatly strengthened. As Frank Moraes put it, 'King Cotton had begun his reign.'[2]

But Purshotamdas was destined to be much more than just a businessman. It is a truism that progress in any sphere whether political, economic, or social is generally the result of the vision, courage and perseverance of a handful of eminent men. This seems to be even truer in the financial and economic spheres and though the name of Sir Purshotamdas Thakurdas carries little resonance for today's generation, his outstanding and manifold contributions to public life, industry, insurance, and banking made him one of the brightest stars in the Indian firmament in the first half of the twentieth century.

Purshotamdas was born in Bombay on May 30, 1879, in the crowded locality of Girgaum in a Gujarati bania family. His father Thakurdas practiced as a solicitor; his uncle Vijbhucandas followed a calling more appropriate to his caste and was in the cotton and oilseeds business, a business the young Purshotamdas was destined to join. Of his parents the young boy was to know very little: Thakurdas passed away at the young age of forty-two; his mother, Diwalibai, too did not live long, passing away two years later.

Purshotamdas was brought up by Vijbhucandas and his wife Ambalaxmi as if he was their own son. Purshotamdas studied at the local Mumbadevi municipal school and then at the Tejpal Anglo-Vernacular School. He was unhappy at both places and finally matriculated from Elphinstone School with unremarkable honours. The only prize he ever won was for French where the kindness and interest of his French teacher, a Mr Sahiar, seems to have spurred him to more meritorious achievement.

Later he joined the Elphinstone College where his career was equally uneventful, but he took active part in extra-curricular activities participating in cricket, tennis, and gymnastics. Purshotamdas passed his BA in the second class in 1900 at the age of twenty-one. He had also been doing law simultaneously and had to choose a career. The choice was between following his father and joining his uncle's business. Purshotamdas motivated by filial sentiment chose the former but the cold response from